



T-storm 71/38 • Tomorrow: Sunny, windy 57/42 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, MARCH 20, 2025 • \$4

Border plan would have troops hold migrants

Order would turn 60-foot buffer zone into satellite military installation

BY DAN LAMOTHE

The Trump administration is evaluating plans for the Pentagon to take control of a buffer zone along a sprawling stretch of the southern border and empower active-duty U.S. troops to temporarily hold migrants who cross into the United States illegally, according to five U.S. officials familiar with the deliberations.

Those discussions have been underway for weeks, and they center, in part, on a section of border in New Mexico, officials said, speaking on the condition of anonymity to disclose details of the plan. In effect, the move would turn the buffer zone into an expansive satellite military installation, potentially allowing a greater portion of the Defense Department's mammoth budget to pay for President Donald Trump's border crackdown while creating new legal jeopardy for those caught trying to slip into the country from Mexico, these people said.

The effort would enable the most significant use yet of active-duty forces at the border under Trump, though any move to militarize the southern border's buffer zone is certain to raise questions about whether employing the military in this way runs afoul of the Posse Comitatus Act, a federal law that prohibits active-duty troops from most law enforcement missions. To date, the Trump administration has addressed such legal considerations by having Customs and Border Protection or Immigration and Customs Enforcement detain people and move them once in custody, including on U.S. military flights involved in its deportation efforts.

If the plan is approved, and administration officials deem it successful, the military-controlled buffer zone, measuring 60

SEE PENTAGON ON A5

New tariffs: Trump prepares levies on imports worth trillions. **A15**

Poll: Federal workers doubt Trump will improve their agencies. **B1**



TAMATI SMITH/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Yami Smith needed shelter last month in Coober Pedy, Australia, on a day set to hit 110 degrees.

Too poor to live belowground

Australian town's respite from extreme heat exacerbates its racial divide

BY MICHAEL E. MILLER
IN COOBER PEDY, AUSTRALIA

From her front door, Sonya Crombie can see the sandstone hills where White men carved up the land in search of opal and then stayed, turning their mines into elaborate underground homes insulated from the desert heat.

But when Crombie's air conditioner broke in November just as the scorching summer was about to set in, the ailing 60-year-old Aboriginal woman had no tunnel in which to take refuge. As

the temperature in her state-run house topped 100 degrees Fahrenheit, Crombie struggled to breathe. Emergency workers flew her 500 miles to a hospital.

"I nearly died," she said. "This heat can kill you."

Extreme heat is surging around the world as climate change drives up temperatures and threatens to force hundreds of millions of people from their homes by 2050. Poor countries will be affected the most.

Australia is one of the wealthiest nations per

SEE AUSTRALIA ON A10

Zelensky accepts limited ceasefire after Trump call

SEEKS 'LASTING PEACE' BUT DOUBTS PUTIN

30-day deal brings hope of finally ending 3-year war

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM
AND LIZZIE JOHNSON

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky agreed Wednesday to a partial ceasefire with Russia focused on "energy and other civilian infrastructure." Zelensky, who spoke after an hour-long phone call with President Donald Trump, said it was a first step in what the Ukrainian leader said he hoped would be "lasting peace" more than three years after his country was invaded by Moscow.

The 30-day ceasefire would be the most concrete result yet of Trump's effort to end the war in Ukraine. It comes a day after Trump had a lengthy conversation with Russian President Vladimir Putin in an attempt to broker a deal and also to restore broader relations with the Kremlin, which have been mostly frozen since the February 2022 invasion of Ukraine.

Both Trump and Zelensky char-

acterized their conversation as positive, a notable shift following their most recent direct encounter that resulted in the Ukrainian leader's ejection from the White House, which had no modern precedent. Zelensky told reporters that Wednesday's exchange was "the most substantive and positive one in recent times."

Still, the conversation between Trump and Zelensky and the timing was just the most recent evidence of how Ukraine has been relegated to the back seat in talks about its future. It came amid questions about whether Putin would live up to the commitments he made to Trump to stop strikes on Ukraine's infrastructure — pledges that fell short of the full

SEE TRUMP ON A12

Deep-strike drones: Inside the program bedeviling Russia. **A9**

'New world order': For Russia, call marks a return to global stage. **A12**

Greenpeace must pay \$667M to oil company

Environmental groups call pipeline protest case an effort to stifle speech

BY ANNA PHILLIPS

Greenpeace must pay the oil company that operates the Dakota Access Pipeline \$667 million in damages for defaming it, a North Dakota jury decided Wednesday — a massive financial blow to the group that environmentalists say could chill future advocacy.

The case, heard at the Morton County courthouse in Mandan, North Dakota, centered on Greenpeace's involvement in the protests over the construction of the Dakota Access Pipeline, which became a cultural flash point in the United States nearly eight years

ago. The protests lasted for months, drawing thousands of people to a site in Cannon Ball, North Dakota, near the Standing Rock Sioux Reservation. Dallas-based Energy Transfer, which runs the nearly 1,200-mile pipeline that carries oil from the Bakken fields in western North Dakota to Illinois, accused Greenpeace of inciting the protests and encouraging violence to damage the company's reputation.

Greenpeace, whose spokesperson confirmed the verdict, has said it played little role in the demonstrations. Major environmental groups have described the lawsuit as an intimidation tactic, intended to stifle free speech and their attempts to stop new oil and gas drilling. Greenpeace plans to appeal, the spokesperson said.

"What we saw over these three weeks was Energy Transfer's

SEE GREENPEACE ON A6

Four friends see new life upended by Enemies Act

Venezuelan migrants taken from Dallas home; families deny gang link

BY SILVIA FOSTER-FRAU

The four friends grew up within blocks of one another in Venezuela, playing soccer and bouncing between each other's homes. As the nation deteriorated, they journeyed to the United States and were eking out a new life in Dallas, where they worked long hours and shared a townhouse.

Then, last Thursday, armed officers showed up at their home, arrested them and took them to a Texas detention center, Mervin Yamarte, 29, told his mother by phone. Family members do not know the charges, if any, and the men's names do not appear in federal, state or local criminal court records.

What happened next horrified the families. Yamarte said they were asked to sign deportation papers and agreed, thinking they would soon be back with their children and loved ones in Venezuela. But a day later, his mother saw a jarring video released by Salvadoran President Nayib Bukele showing alleged gang members being violently pulled off planes from the United States and dragged to a megaprison notorious for allegations of human rights abuses.

Mercedes Yamarte spotted her son.

He appears for only a second, but she has no doubt it is Mervin. He is kneeling and wearing a ripped black shirt. His head has been shaved. An officer stands behind him. He appears to be wincing.

"I didn't have words," Mercedes

SEE PRISONERS ON A4

'Dangerous': Japanese Americans warn against Alien Enemies Act. **A3**

As ceasefire falls, new anguish for hostage families

Relatives of Israelis held by Hamas say that fighting puts captives at risk and that time is running out

BY SHIRA RUBIN

TEL AVIV — When Israel and Hamas reached a ceasefire in late January, Sharon Cunio suspected her husband, David, would not be among the first of the Israeli hostages to come home. He was a young man and, she surmised, a high-value bargaining chip that Hamas would keep until later phases of the ceasefire.

On Tuesday, Israel resumed its aerial bombardment of Gaza, and, Cunio said, her "world collapsed." She imagined him languishing in the tunnels under Gaza and feared he would die under the rubble or be killed by his captors.

Cunio, like dozens of Israelis whose relatives are still in captivity, said she was shocked and terrified by Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's decision to restart the war. The massive airstrikes were followed Wednesday

SEE ISRAEL ON A13

Troops in Gaza: Israel recaptures key territory on a deadly day. **A13**



JOHN WESSELS/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Demonstrators carrying white umbrellas Wednesday in Jerusalem call for an end to the war in Gaza.

IN THE NEWS

Interest rates held steady The Fed continued its cautious approach, and its chair said tariffs are already playing a role in inflation. **A15**

The tone of the town For more than three decades, John Widmann has climbed the stairs of Frederick's 70-foot tower on Sundays to play the Maryland city's carillon. **B1**

THE NATION
A judge denied a request by the U.S. Institute of Peace to temporarily stop a takeover by the U.S. DOGE Service. **A2**
Arizona carried out its first execution of a prisoner since 2022. **A6**

THE WORLD
Pork-loving China has instituted 10 percent tariffs on U.S. farm goods, but the retaliatory move isn't likely to hurt consumers there because of the country's vast production. **A8**

THE ECONOMY
Mortgage giants Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac saw their boards suddenly overhauled by the Trump administration this week. **A14**
Congress is worried after Trump moved to shut down a project that helped millions in China access the open web. **A16**

THE REGION
A missing shoe was a crucial clue in solving an attempted-carjacking case in Montgomery County, police said. **B1**
A federal judge halted the EPA's bid to kill a \$14 billion Biden climate grant fund on fraud claims, citing a lack of "credible evidence." **B1**

STYLE
Woolly Mammoth's Maria Manuela Goyanes is leaving the D.C. theater company for a job with New York's Lincoln Center Theater. **C1**

LOCAL LIVING
Can plant growth really be improved by playing music? It probably can't hurt.

BUSINESS NEWS.....A14
COMICS.....C5
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A17
TELEVISION.....C4
WORLD NEWS.....A8

CONTENT © 2025
The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54161

